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PER CENT
urban respondents rate Rahul Gandhi's performance as LoP outstanding; 22% in rural India

The INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN), January 2026, survey captures the Opposition at a moment that is politically more precarious than it appears on the surface. Nowhere is the Opposition, and particularly the Congress, a decisive presence anymore. It speaks often, protests loudly, and occupies the moral high ground with conviction, yet struggles to translate any of this into political leverage. The electorate has not turned away from the Opposition. It has simply stopped expecting much from it.

At the centre of this uneasy equilibrium remains Rahul Gandhi. He continues to be the most recognisable Opposition face, with 28.6 per cent of the respondents seeing him as best suited to lead the Opposition alliance, virtually unchanged from August 2025. The ambivalence becomes clearer when voters are asked to judge Rahul's performance as Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha. A combined 44 per cent rate his performance 'outstanding' or 'good', but nearly 31 per cent also view it as 'poor/very poor'. What's worse: this is a six percentage point drop, from the 50 per cent positive rating in August '25.

This uncertainty spills over into perceptions of the Congress as an Opposition party. Its overall rating has slipped since August 2025, from 47.2 per cent describing it as 'outstanding' or 'good' to 41 per cent now. The decline is sharper when respondents are asked if the Congress is the real Opposition.

One reason for this erosion is that the Congress has become adept at articulation but poor at conversion. Nowhere is this more evident than in its embrace of the 'vote chori' narrative. Allegations of institutional bias, compromised election machinery, and democratic distortion dominate Opposition discourse. Intellectually, the argument resonates. Electorally, it does not. The Bihar poll results remain the most damning illustration of this.

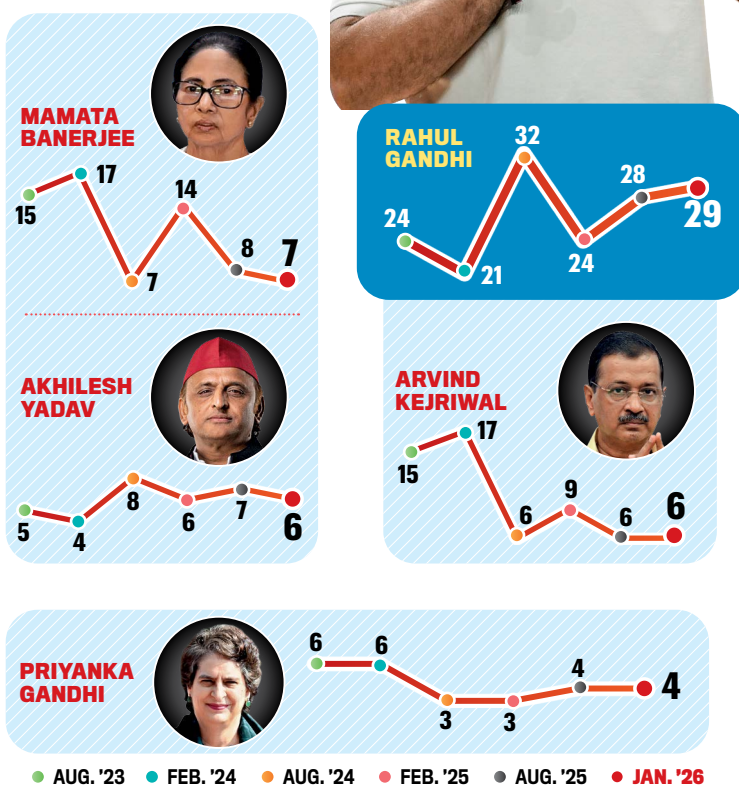
The strain is evident in the Congress leadership question. Despite a marginal dip, Rahul remains the frontrunner with 35.6 per cent support, while Priyanka Gandhi shows a modest uptick to 8.6 per cent.

The Congress's failure has also

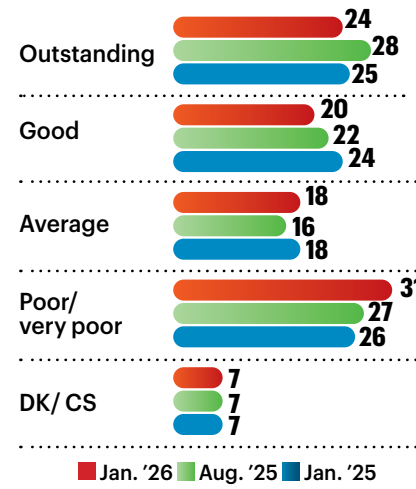


ARUN KUMAR

Q. Who, among the current leaders, is best-suited to lead the Opposition alliance?



Q. How do you rate Rahul Gandhi's performance as Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha?



Rahul still gets accolades, but there are more now who are unconvinced

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/CS: Don't know/can't say